A Noiseless Patient Spider

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1. In stanza 1, what is the spider literally doing?

The spider stands alone on a small piece of land jutting out. It keeps sending out threads of silk into the open space, trying to find something they can attach to so it can build its web.

2. How are the soul and spider similar? Give at least two examples.

First, both are isolated in a huge space. The spider faces the "vacant vast surrounding," while the soul is "detached" in "measureless oceans of space." Second, both keep reaching out for a connection. The spider sends out silk threads, while the soul keeps "musing, venturing, throwing, seeking" to find meaning and a place to belong. The thread catching on something represents the connection the soul hopes to find.

3. Explain interesting diction or syntax.

The repetition of "filament, filament, filament" makes the spider's attempts feel continuous, as if it keeps sending out one thread after another. Similarly, the list "musing, venturing, throwing, seeking" shows the soul's constant effort. Repeating "Till" near the end emphasizes that the search will continue until a connection is made.

4. What emotion best describes the final mood?

The final mood is hopeful. Although the soul has not found a connection yet, the repeated "Till" suggests that it will keep trying. The images of a bridge and an anchor suggest the belonging and stability it hopes to reach.

5. How does the poem represent transcendental beliefs?

The speaker learns about his own soul by observing a spider, showing the transcendental belief that nature can reveal spiritual truths. The connection between the spider's actions and the soul's search also suggests that people and nature are connected. Like the spider producing threads "out of itself," the soul draws on its own inner strength to keep searching.